

Energy Transport in Conductors: A Field-Based View of EMI in Avionics Wiring

Jesus Alberto Perea García
Mechatronics Engineering, IEST Anáhuac

September 2026

Abstract

Engineering intuition often treats wires as simple pipes for energy. Yet, this analogy fails to explain the massive gap between the slow drift of electrons ($v_d \approx \text{mm/s}$) and the near light-speed propagation of signals. By analyzing the Poynting Vector, this note shows that energy does not flow *through* the charge carriers, but rather propagates via the electromagnetic fields *surrounding* the conductor. We apply this field-centric perspective to a critical challenge in aerospace avionics: Electromagnetic Interference (EMI). In the crowded environment of a spacecraft, we show that mitigation strategies like twisted pairs and coaxial shielding are not just barriers; they are geometric tools designed to reshape and confine the external energy volume, preventing the unwanted field coupling between conductors known as crosstalk.

1 Introduction

By historical convention, electric current is defined as the flow of positive charges; this convention was introduced by Benjamin Franklin [1]. Today we know that electric current is carried by electrons, while energy transport occurs primarily through the electromagnetic fields surrounding the conductor, as described by the Poynting vector and Maxwell's equations [4], [8], [9].

When a potential difference (voltage) is applied across a conductor, an electric field is established throughout the material. Although it is often stated that "electricity travels at the speed of light," the reality is more sophisticated. The drift velocity of electrons flowing in a typical copper wire carrying ordinary current is on the order of millimeters per second.

$$v_d = \frac{I}{nqA} \quad (1)$$

Where:

- v_d : Drift velocity of charge carriers
- I : Current
- n : Number density of charge carriers
- A : Conductor cross-sectional area
- q : Magnitude of the carrier charge

2 Atomic Level: The Drude Perspective

At the microscopic level, metallic conductors consist of a fixed lattice of positive ions and a sea of free electrons. When a potential difference is applied, the internal electric field exerts a local force on these free electrons ($\mathbf{F} = -e\mathbf{E}$), causing them to drift opposite to the field lines. Note that only the electrons move; the positive ions remain stationary within the lattice.

2.1 Surface Charge Distribution: Boundary Conditions

A common misconception is that charges reside on the surface solely due to electrostatic repulsion. While Coulomb repulsion exists, in a current-carrying wire (electrodynamics), the surface charge distribution serves a specific function: meeting the boundary conditions.

As Jefimenko explains [6], surface charges arrange themselves in a gradient to maintain a uniform longitudinal electric field inside the wire. Without this specific surface distribution, the electric field would not correctly conform to the geometry of the conductor, preventing steady current flow. Thus, the surface charges act as "guides" for the internal field.

2.2 Neutrality of the Bulk

Starting from the continuity equation for steady currents ($\nabla \cdot \mathbf{J} = 0$) and substituting the microscopic Ohm's Law ($\mathbf{J} = \sigma \mathbf{E}$), we obtain:

$$\nabla \cdot (\sigma \mathbf{E}) = \sigma(\nabla \cdot \mathbf{E}) + \mathbf{E} \cdot \nabla \sigma = 0 \quad (2)$$

For a homogeneous conductor, the conductivity is spatially constant ($\nabla \sigma = 0$). Consequently, the equation simplifies to $\nabla \cdot \mathbf{E} = 0$. By applying Gauss's Law ($\nabla \cdot \mathbf{E} = \rho/\epsilon_0$), it follows that the volume charge density vanishes ($\rho = 0$) to an excellent approximation; the residual bulk charge is a relativistic effect of order v_d^2/c^2 [7].

$$Q_{enc} = \int \rho dV = 0 \quad (3)$$

Thus, as a direct consequence of Maxwell's equations and material homogeneity, any excess charge introduced by the circuit must reside on the conductor surface to satisfy the electromagnetic boundary conditions [4].

3 Surface Charge Gradient

Upon applying a voltage, charges redistribute to the surface to produce the internal electric field required to sustain steady current flow. On the negative side of the wire, we find an excess of electrons; conversely, at the positive end, we observe a depletion of electrons.

This leads to a subtle but crucial mechanism. Since the bulk of the wire is electrically neutral, a charge carrier in the center experiences zero net repulsive force from its neighbors. Because the bulk remains electrically neutral, electrons do not experience net Coulomb forces from neighboring charge carriers. Instead, the driving force comes entirely from the *surface*. The gradient of surface charges generates an internal electric field that penetrates the neutral core, exerting the necessary force to drift the electrons forward.

This gradient creates a constant, longitudinal Electric Field (E_{axial}) inside the wire's "neutral" core. As demonstrated by Jefimenko [6], unlike in electrostatics where the internal field is zero, here the surface charges guide the field lines through the wire, acting as a "rail" that pushes the inner free electrons steadily.

4 Microscopic Ohm's Law

A fundamental paradox arises: if an electric field exerts a constant force ($\mathbf{F} = q\mathbf{E}$) on electrons, Newton's laws suggest, that such a force should produce unbounded acceleration. Why then, is the drift velocity so low ($v_d \approx \text{mm/s}$)?

The answer lies in the crystalline lattice structure. This interaction is classically described by the **Drude Model**, where electrons accelerate under the electric field for an average time τ before colliding with lattice ions. These frequent scattering events limit their motion, resulting in a steady-state drift velocity rather than unbounded acceleration [3], [4].

This interaction is described by the microscopic form of Ohm's Law:

$$\mathbf{J} = \sigma \mathbf{E} \quad (4)$$

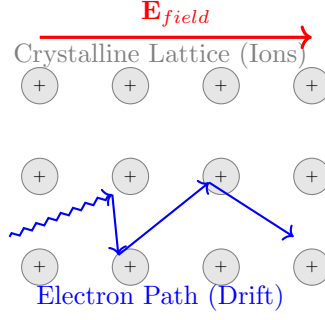


Figure 1: Microscopic transport in a crystalline lattice. Electrons undergo frequent scattering with lattice ions, impurities, and phonons while acquiring a net drift velocity under the applied electric field, transferring energy to the lattice as Joule heat.

Where $\mathbf{J}$ is the current density (A/m^2) and σ is the material's conductivity. This equation unifies the driving force ($\mathbf{E}$) with the intrinsic resistance of the material to flow.

5 Poynting Vector Analysis

To determine the true path of energy flow, we define the Poynting Vector $\mathbf{S}$, which represents the directional energy flux density (Watts per unit area, W/m^2) transferred through the electromagnetic field:

$$\mathbf{S} = \frac{1}{\mu_0}(\mathbf{E} \times \mathbf{B}) \quad (5)$$

Where μ_0 is the vacuum permeability.

Inside the wire and at its surface, electrons arrange themselves in a steady-state distribution to facilitate flow. As established in Section 3, this surface alignment creates a longitudinal Electric Field ($\mathbf{E}$) that drives the current. Simultaneously, according to Ampère's Law, this movement generates an azimuthal Magnetic Field ($\mathbf{B}$) that surrounds the wire.

Calculating the cross product $\mathbf{E} \times \mathbf{B}$ at the surface of the conductor reveals the direction of energy transfer. Since $\mathbf{E}$ is primarily axial ($\hat{z}$) and $\mathbf{B}$ is azimuthal ($\hat{\phi}$), the resulting Poynting vector has a radial component:

$$\mathbf{S}_{surface} \propto -\hat{r} \quad (6)$$

This negative radial direction ($-\hat{r}$) signifies that energy flows from the surrounding fields **into** the wire to be dissipated as heat (Joule heating). However, in the dielectric space surrounding the wire, the dominant fields propel the energy parallel to the wire ($\hat{z}$) towards the load.

5.1 The Wire as a Guide, Not a Pipe

This leads to a critical conclusion: electrons, moving at a drift velocity of mere mm/s, do not carry the signal energy. Instead, the conductive wire acts as a guide. The surface charges establish the boundary conditions that allow the electromagnetic fields to propagate the bulk of the energy through the dielectric (air or insulation) at near light speed. The energy absorbed by the wire (indicated by the inward $-\hat{r}$ Poynting component) is merely the "toll" paid in resistive losses for guiding these fields.

6 Implications: Aerospace EMI

The realization that energy propagates through the electromagnetic field outside the conductor ($\mathbf{S}_{axial}$) rather than inside the bulk has profound implications for aerospace avionics. In spacecraft and launch vehicles, wiring harnesses are densely packed due to severe mass and volume constraints. Since conductors act as guides for external electromagnetic fields, these fields necessarily extend into the surrounding space, enabling unintended coupling between adjacent circuits.

6.1 Crosstalk Mechanism

When two signal cables run parallel in close proximity, their electromagnetic field distributions overlap. Because energy propagates via these fields rather than through the copper itself, the expanding field of a high-power line can invade the space of a nearby low-level sensor line. This produces induced voltages through both capacitive coupling (via $\mathbf{E}$ -field overlap) and inductive coupling (via time-varying magnetic flux). In the field-centric model, the fields of adjacent lines superpose, $\mathbf{E} = \mathbf{E}_1 + \mathbf{E}_2$ and $\mathbf{B} = \mathbf{B}_1 + \mathbf{B}_2$. Because the Poynting vector is quadratic in the fields, the total flux is not simply $\mathbf{S}_1 + \mathbf{S}_2$: the cross terms $\mu_0^{-1}(\mathbf{E}_1 \times \mathbf{B}_2 + \mathbf{E}_2 \times \mathbf{B}_1)$ represent energy exchanged between the circuits, which appears as crosstalk in an otherwise electrically isolated line [4], [5].

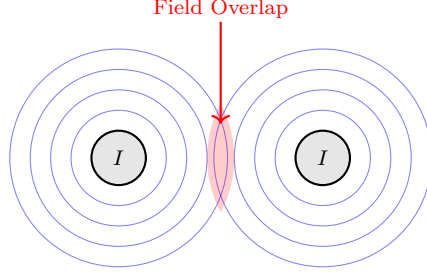


Figure 2: Cross-sectional view of crosstalk. The overlapping electromagnetic fields create a shared volume where the fields superpose; the cross terms of the Poynting vector carry energy from one circuit to the other, leading to signal degradation.

6.2 Field Confinement Strategies

To mitigate this, aerospace engineers employ geometries that reshape and confine electromagnetic energy flow:

- **Twisted Pair:** The forward and return conductors carry equal and opposite currents ($+I$ and $-I$), producing magnetic fields of opposite circulation. At distances large compared to the conductor separation s , the net magnetic field satisfies

$$\mathbf{B}_{net} \sim \mathcal{O}(s/r) \rightarrow 0, \quad (7)$$

indicating that the field strength decays rapidly as the distance r increases relative to the wire separation s . Consequently, the external Poynting vector $\mathbf{S}_{ext} = \mu_0^{-1}(\mathbf{E}_{net} \times \mathbf{B}_{net})$ is strongly suppressed, confining energy transport to the immediate dielectric region between the conductors rather than allowing it to radiate into surrounding space.

- **Coaxial Shielding:** In coaxial geometries, the return current flows on the outer conductor, equal and opposite to the center current. By Ampère's Law, the net enclosed current outside the shield vanishes, yielding $\mathbf{B}_{ext} = 0$. Similarly, Gauss's Law implies $\mathbf{E}_{ext} = 0$ due to zero net enclosed charge. Therefore,

$$\mathbf{S}_{ext} = \frac{1}{\mu_0}(\mathbf{E}_{ext} \times \mathbf{B}_{ext}) = 0, \quad (8)$$

and electromagnetic energy transport is strictly confined to the dielectric region between conductors, making an ideal coaxial line immune to both radiation and external interference.

Together, the use of twisted pairs and coaxial geometries allows effective confinement of electromagnetic fields through the cancellation of opposing currents, reducing outward energy flow. From the perspective of the Poynting vector, this confinement limits energy propagation to the dielectric region between conductors, decreasing crosstalk and electromagnetic interference [4], [5].

7 Conclusion

This note has challenged the classical intuition of electric current. We have shown that while electrons drift slowly inside the conductor to satisfy continuity, the energy propagates near the speed of light through the external electromagnetic field.

The conductive wire is not a simple pipe for energy; it is a complex guiding structure. The surface charges act as the architects, arranging themselves to guide the external fields, while the core electrons drift to sustain the magnetic field. For the mechatronics engineer, this shift in perspective—from "flow in wires" to "guided fields"—is essential. It explains why we twist cables, why we shield sensors, and how energy truly moves from source to load. Mastering the field is the only way to master the circuit.

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